NieR:Automata™

Game of the YoRHa Edition

UNIVERSIDADE LUSÓFONA

Crítica e Análise de Videojogos
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Introdution

Intro 00-01

Nier: Automata is an action hack and slash game with a compelling story, initially released at the beginning of 2017 for PC and PlayStation and later ported for Xbox and Nintendo Switch. Being written by Yoko Taro, a Japanese video game director and scenario writer known for his compeling and thought-provoking stories that really make one reflect not only on themselves but on the whole human race and what it really means to be human.

Game Cover

Published and developed by Platinum Games, known for having excelent combat, Nier is no different. Being one of the best in the hack and slash genre that I have ever played, with its buttery smooth controls and fast past combat, it's an amazing experience that I recommend to any lover of action games.

Publisher and Developer logos

Story

Story 01-01: World Setting

Finding ourselves in the year 11945 in a post-apocaliptic world, we the androids have the mission to exterminate all machine life forms on earth so that our creators, the humans, can once again repopulate it.

Starting the game, we are met with a message from one of our protagonists, 2B, a female android, quoting, "Everything that lives is designed to end. We are perpetually trapped in a never-ending spiral of death. Is this a curse? Or some kind of punishment? I often think about the god who blessed us with this cryptic puzzle and wonder if we will have the chance to kill him." and then we are put in the starting mission of the game, receiving an audio message from our pod, informing us of the mission we are about to begin.

Opening combat scene

Story

Story 01-02: The Characters

Nier follows the story of three androids: 2B, the battler type, 9S, the scanner, and A2, an attack unit, this one being an earlier iteration of the battler model only being playable near the end of the game, as this one is understood as a villain in the eyes of the 2B and 9S at the start of the game.

2B - 9S - A2

Story

Story 01-03: The Acts

The game is separated into 3 acts:

-The first one we play as 2B, and it takes us half way through.
-In the second act we control 9s, we go through the same things as 2B, but in his perspective, here we also find out that he is able to hear machine thoughts, which gives us a different perspective on their behavior.
-In the third act, we go back and forward as 2B, 9S, and A2.

A funny thing about Nier:Automata is that there are 26 endings, each one accounting for a letter of the alphabet. Of course, most of these endings are non-canon and just different possibilities of what could have happened if the playable character had done something different.
My first encounter with these alternative endings was when I was exploring an area as 9s and suddenly I got a credit roll screen. At the time, I got really confused, as I had just started the second act of the game.
The canon endings are A-B-C-D-E, which you need to complete if you wish to experience or if you wish to understand the whole story.

Exemple of a game file with all the endings

Gameplay

Gameplay 02-01: 2B and A2

Playing as 2B and A2, the combat is action-packed, featuring dashes, fast attacks, and special moves; these all come together to create a mesmerizing dance that is extremely satisfying to the player. We can find small differences between 2B and A2, such as animations and different "special moves." 2B can explode herself, ending up at 1 health point and dealing massive damage around her. As A2, the player can activate a berserker mode, increasing his stats but only lasting for a few seconds, but they end up playing very similary.

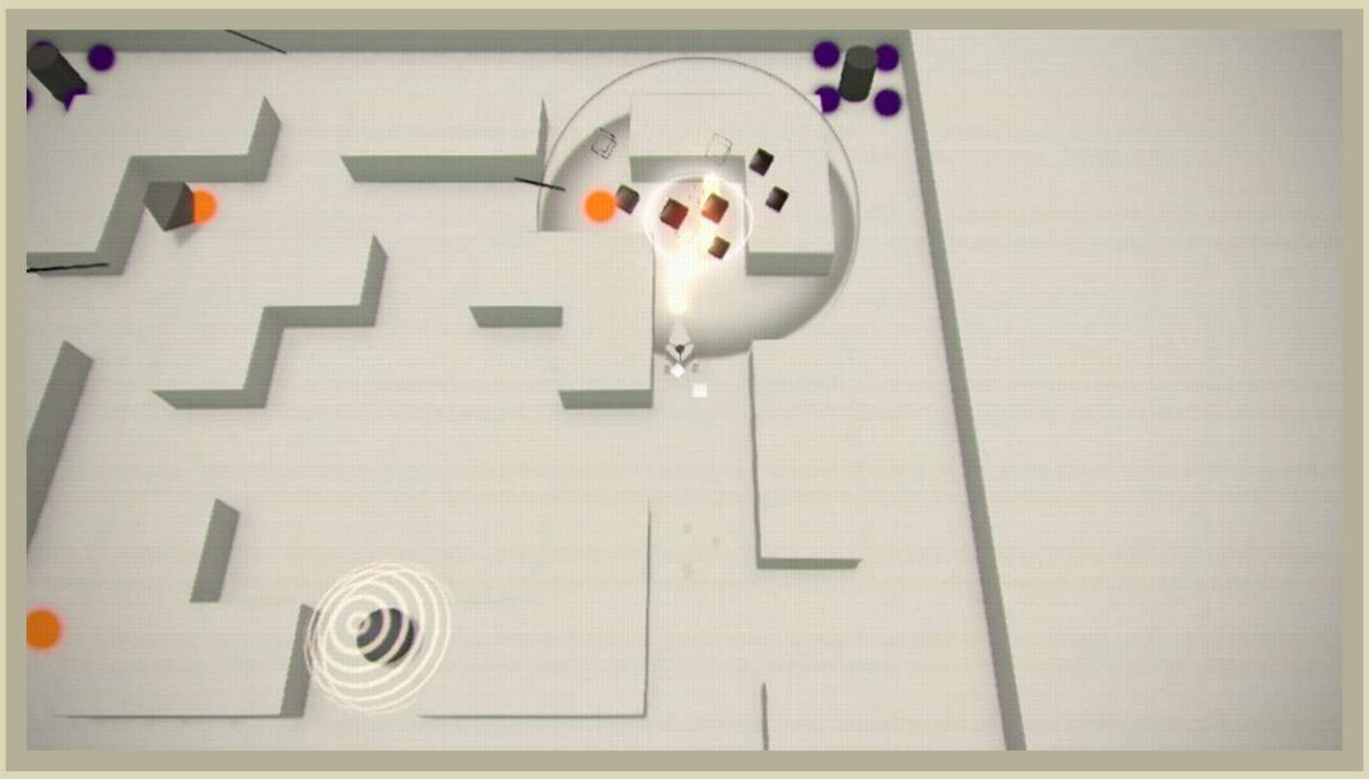
Melee Combat

Gameplay

Gameplay 02-02: 9S and Hacking

As 9s, we find ourselves having to play more technically as he features weaker physical attacks, but it comes with a powerful hack that, upon completion, makes the enemies explode. I should also mention that this hack is not only used in combat scenarios coming up in different aspects of the game, such as opening chests and progressing through out the story.

9S combat

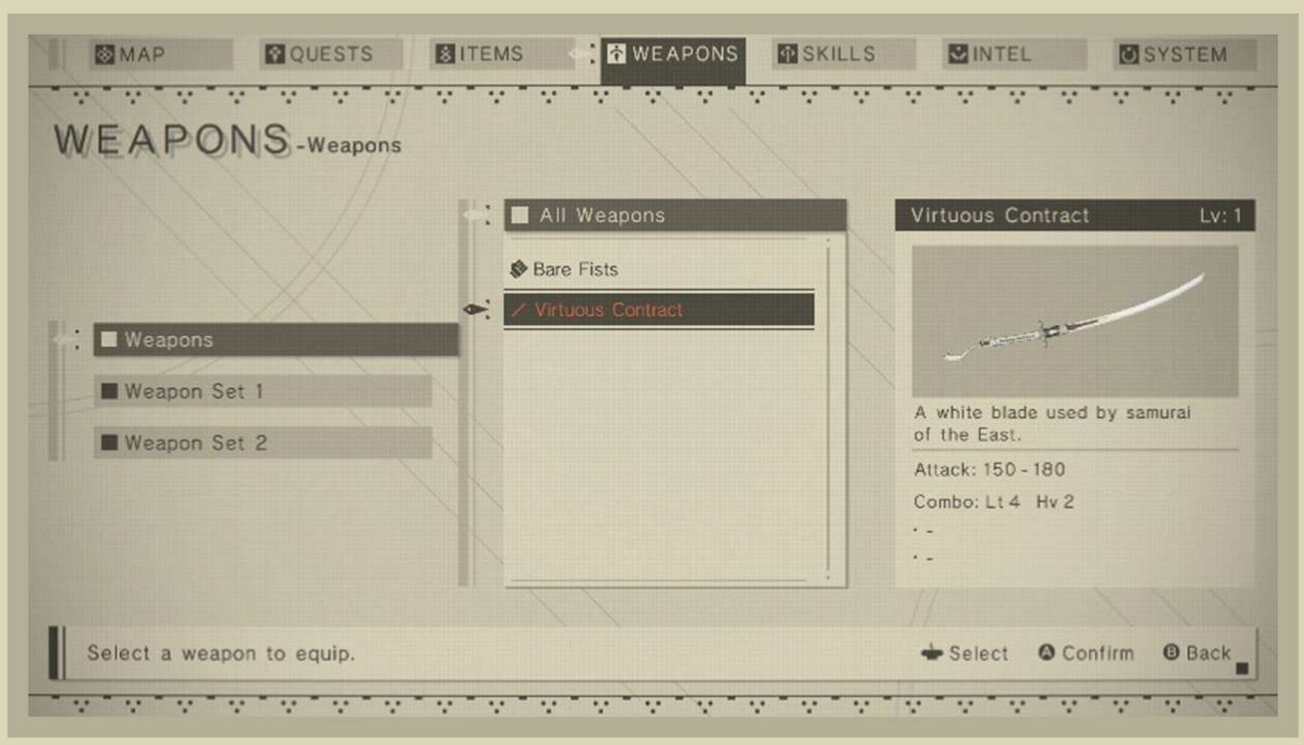


Hacking Mini Game

Gameplay

Gameplay 02-03: Arsenal

All the characters are able to use two different weapons and are equipped with a pod, a floating robot that features a variety of ranged attacks, from missles to lazers to a giant hammer that crushes enemies.



Weapon Menus

Gameplay

Gameplay 02-04: Flight unit

In addition to regular combat, we have a couple missions where we fight on a flight unit. For example, during the aforementioned first mission of the game, we start the mission on one of these flight units. They are equipped with a sword and machine guns that help our playable characters bring destruction to their enemies.

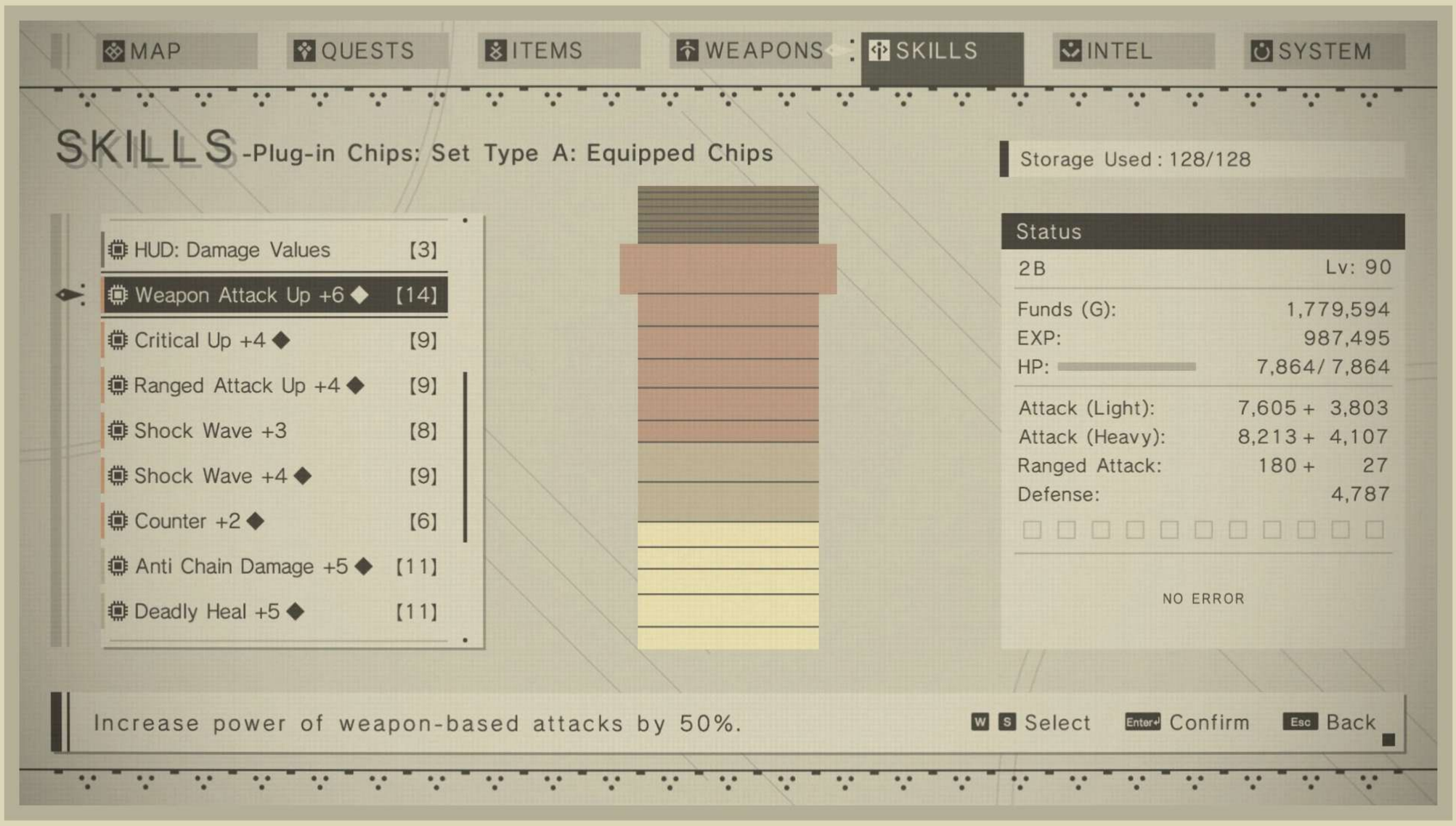
Flight Unit Combat

Gameplay

Gameplay 02-05: The chips

Behind it all there is a upgrade system called chips. These chips increase the playable character stats or even give them abilities ranging from a simple atack increase to a time-slowing effect when you perform a perfect dodge.

Again talking about the endings, if we open the chips menu and remove a certain chip from the system category, the credits of the game will roll, giving us one of its 26 endings.



Chips Menu

Gameplay

Gameplay 02-06: The music

What can it even say about this game's music? It's brilliant. Not only does it intensify the battle and combat scenes, it makes it perfectly portray the emotion we are suppoused to feel when going through out a zone.

For example, there is this amusement park in the beginning of the game where the music is eerie, which gave me the chills when going through it the first time. At the start of the area, I didn't give it much though, but eventually we find out this part is actually a cult led by a powerful machine, and that's just a perfectly organized way to protraid a story through something that is in the background. Not to mention the ending music that just makes you rethink the entire story while going through a never-ending roller coaster of emotions.

Ending Credits

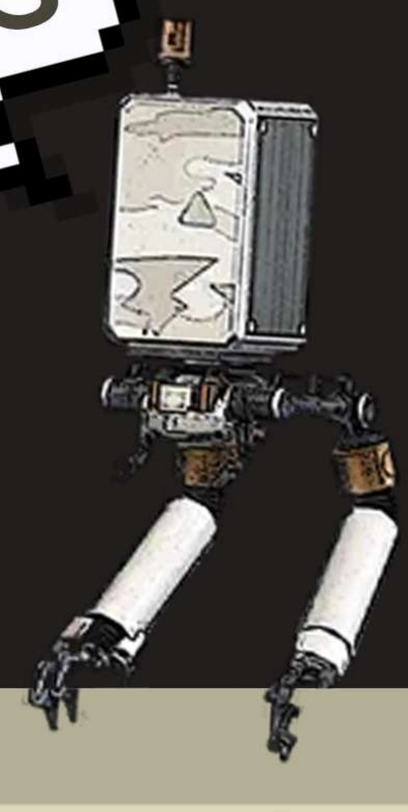
Conclusion

Conclusion 03-01

I could stay here and inumerate hundreds on top of thousands of reasons why I love Nier:Automata.
But at the end of the day, it boils down to how good the story was and how satisfying the gameplay is.
It was the very first game that had me caring about its story, and by the conclusion I had tears in my eyes due to the things it made me feel and how brilliantly protraid its message was.

It's a masterpiece that I recommend to every single action lover to play. Not to mention that this is one of the games along with Dark Souls 3 that made me want to pursue game design, and I have Yoko Taro to thank and the team behind him for creating such an amazing game.

References



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